Summary

Public Steam reviews reveal different friction points across playtime stages.

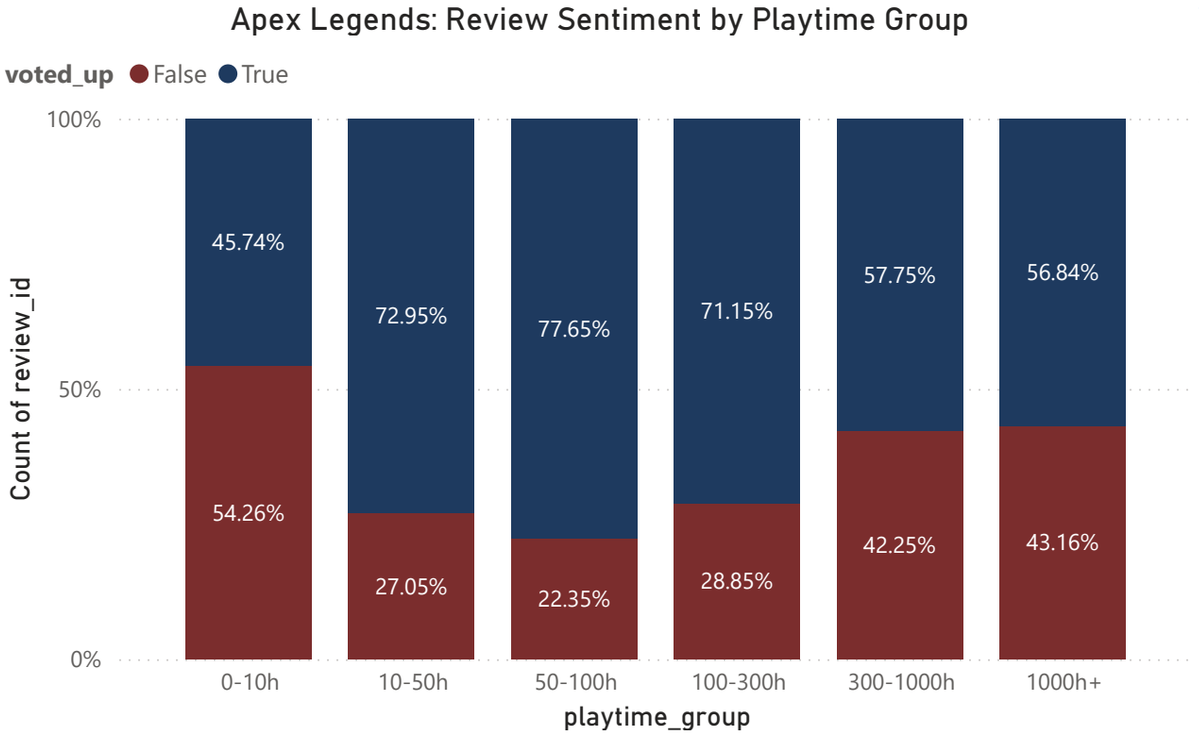
This report analyses English-language Steam reviews for Apex Legends, Icarus, and Path of Exile to understand how player dissatisfaction appears across different playtime stages.

The dataset contains approximately 1,400-1,500 Steam reviews per game, filtered to English-language entries and grouped by playtime at review. Sentiment is based on Steam's recommendation label: "recommended" reviews are treated as positive, while "not recommended" reviews are treated as negative.

Keyword and phrase themes were extracted in Python from review text and grouped into product-relevant categories such as onboarding friction, DLC/value perception, server stability, league mechanics, content pacing, cheating, and developer trust. Power BI was used to visualise playtime-stage risk, recurring complaint themes, and differences between player praise and dissatisfaction.

The goal is not to rank the games or diagnose internal retention, but to identify directional product signals from public reviews across playtime stages.

Apex Legends — A Game That Never Earns Trust

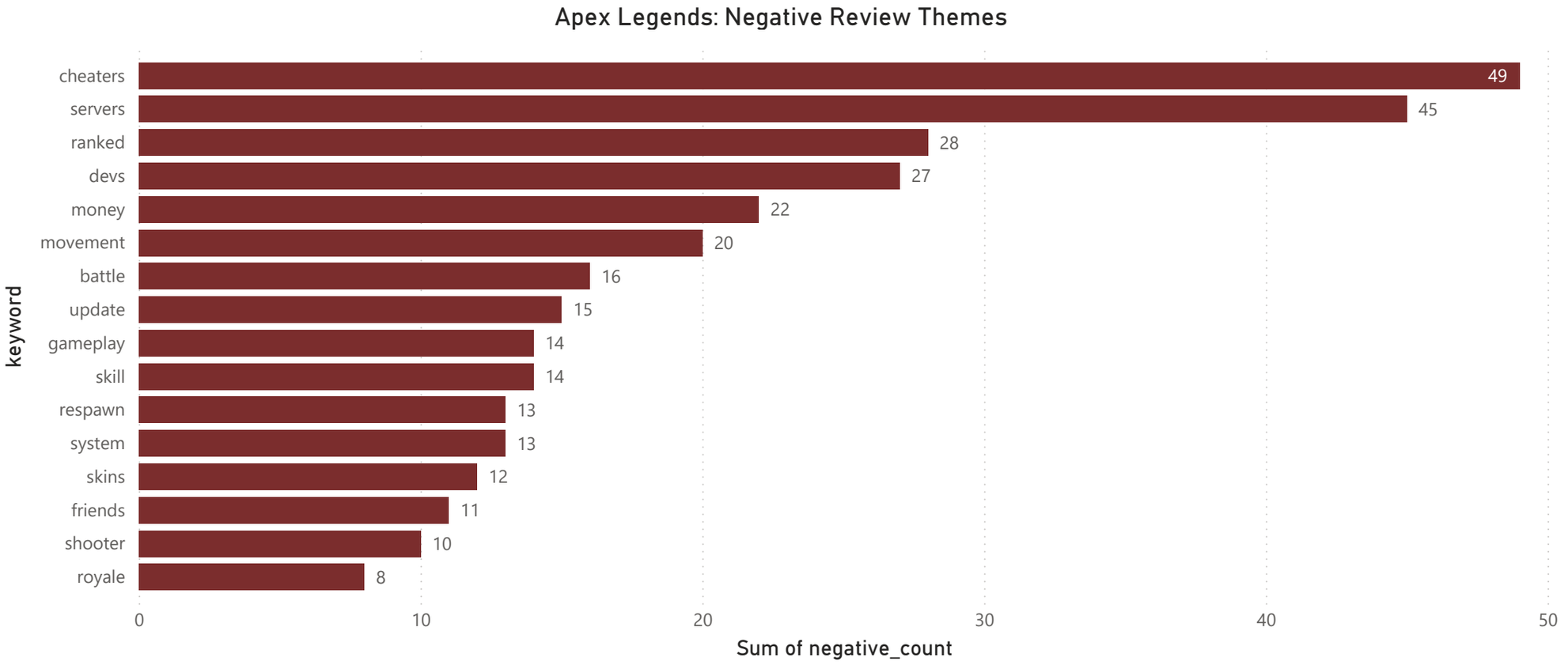


review_text	voted_up	playtime_hours
- grind 1 and half week - get hardstuck to diamond 4 forever	True	773.70
"A Masterclass in Movement Ruined by Poor Management" I have put hundreds of hours into this game, and it kills me to write this, but I can't recommend Apex in its current state. At its core, the gunplay and movement are the best in the genre, but every other system in the game feels like it's designed to frustrate the player. The "Competitive" Nightmare The Matchmaking: If you have even one decent game, the SBMM (Skill-Based Matchmaking) immediately throws you into "Predator" lobbies. There is no such thing as a "chill" match anymore. You are either sweating for your life or getting rolled by a 3-stack of pro-level players while your teammates are still learning how to slide-jump. The Cheating Crisis: Even in 2026, the "infection rate" of cheaters is exhausting. Whether it's soft-aim bots, wallhacks, or recoil scripts (Cronus/XIM), it feels like half of my deaths in Diamond rank are suspicious. Respawn posts ban numbers, but the game is free-to-play, so they just come right back on new accounts.	False	591.40

Key Findings

Apex Legends has a trust problem, not a core gameplay problem.
Negative review rate drops from 54.7% at 0-10h to 21.9% at 50-100h, suggesting that players who reach the core loop often enjoy the game.
However, dissatisfaction rises again among veterans, reaching 42-43% after 300h.
This pattern points to accumulated frustration rather than failed onboarding: cheating, matchmaking, ranked pressure, server issues, and perceived developer inaction become more visible the longer players stay.
The product risk is clear: Apex can win players through movement and gunplay, but struggles to retain trust over time.

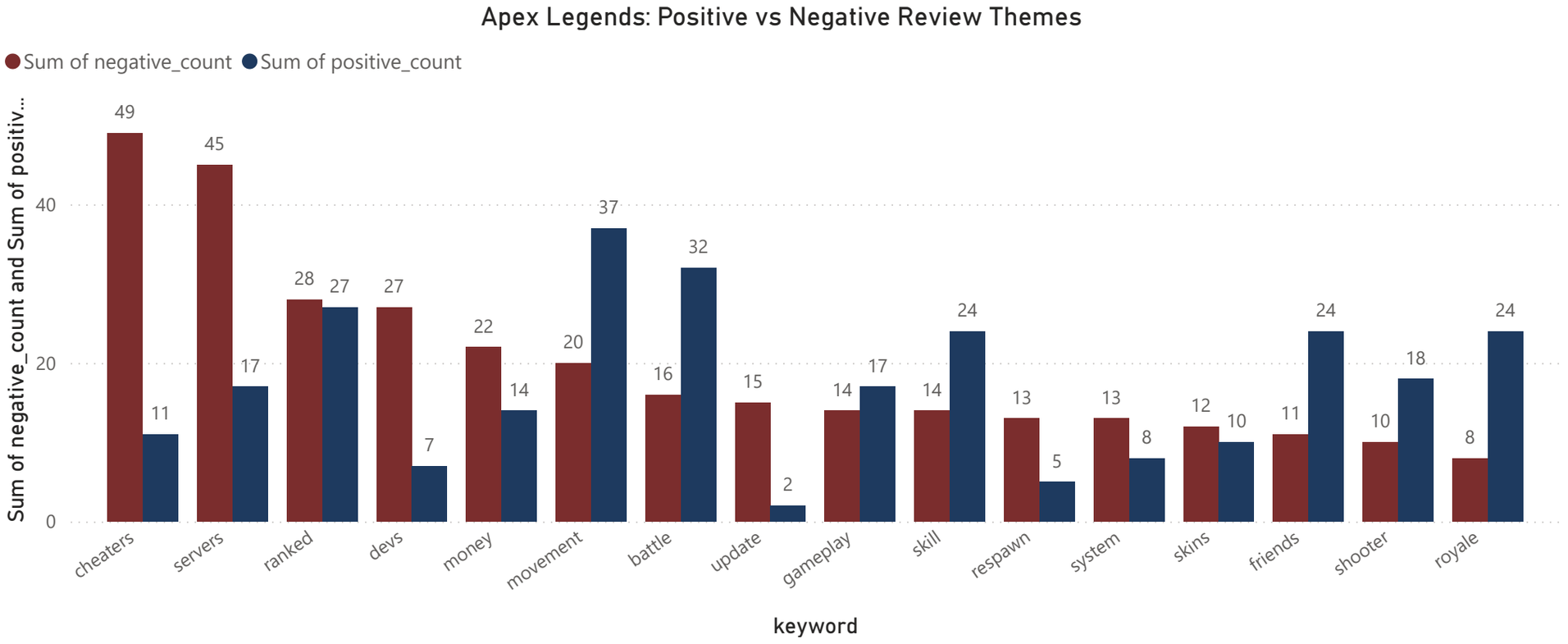
Apex Legends — The Broken Environment



Key Findings

The strongest negative themes are not about Apex's core mechanics, but the environment around them. Cheaters (49) and servers (45) dominate negative reviews, while ranked, developer responsiveness, and monetisation form the next layer of frustration.
This points to a competitive trust problem: players may still value Apex's movement, gunplay, and squad-based combat, but the match environment feels increasingly unfair or unstable.
For a live-service shooter, this is especially damaging. When players lose confidence in anti-cheat, server quality, matchmaking, and developer response, frustration accumulates even among those who still like the game itself.

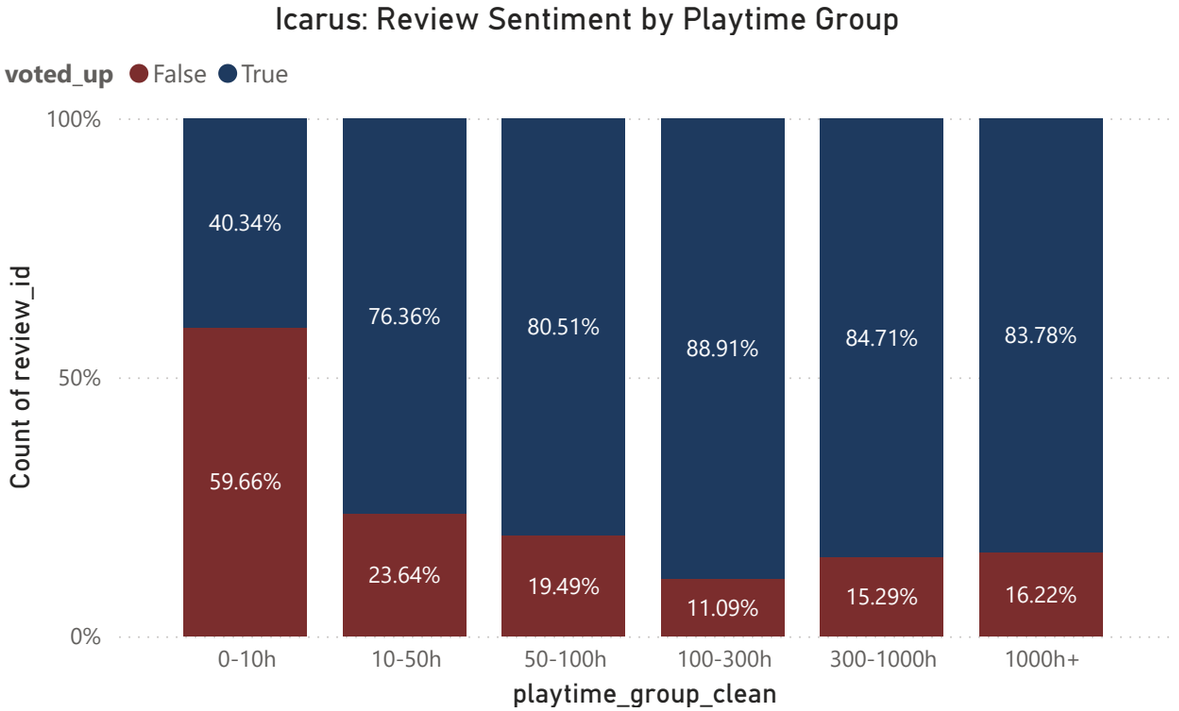
Apex Legends — Love the Game, Hate the Experience



Key Findings

Players still love the game Apex is built around. Movement, battle, friends, and royale skew positive, showing that the core loop remains a major strength.
However, negative themes such as cheaters, servers, and ranked also appear inside positive reviews. This suggests a "yes, but" pattern: many players still recommend Apex, but their praise comes with warnings about fairness, stability, and trust.
The product risk is conditional loyalty. Apex is strong enough to keep players emotionally invested, but repeated live-service frustrations may turn recommendation into churn over time.

Icarus — Where Players Drop Off



review_text	voted_up	playtime_hours
$200 for the whole thing when it is still this janky after all these years. Seriously, nah. The difficulty settings are a joke, especially when there is a button that looks like it might give you more granular control only to have a single button in there for turning the spiders off. That has to be a joke of some sort, only I'm not laughing. The game itself has loads of janky mechanics as well, that don't seem to follow a consistent logic. It tries to add some looter shooter element in there with character creation and equipment, but as far as I can tell that's not actually necessary to play either and you start from scratch anyhow. The game world is illogical af telling you that oxygen is required in a lush forest with trees as tall as buildings, while going overly realistic on other mechanics like food spoiling. The animals are braindead or lazer guided, but nothing in between. You can essentially cheese your way to higher levels just chopping trees for days. Multiplayer keeps glitching out and has a tendency to drop you below the map or otherwise trap you. Not sure what it is about the graphics, but it feels like one of those way too realistic texture packs from Minecraft at times, might just be the shading. For the relatively basic look it taxes hardware quite a bit and it seems to just get worse performance the longer you play.	False	9.25

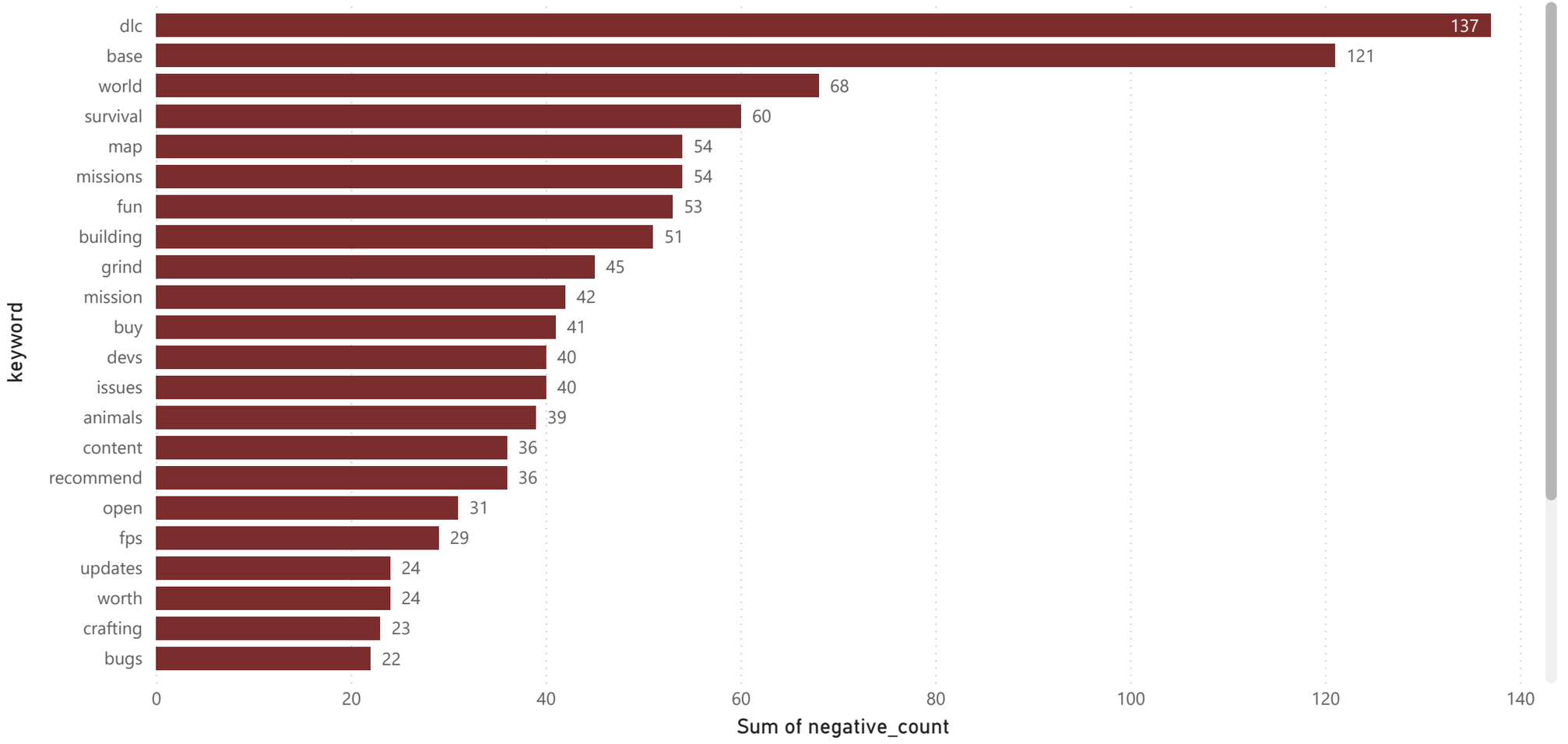
Key Findings

Icarus loses players before the core loop fully lands. Negative review rate is highest at 0-10h (59.7%), then falls sharply after 50h, suggesting that players who get past the early friction are much more likely to recommend the game.

The main risk is therefore early conversion, not long-term rejection. Onboarding clarity, early pacing, technical stability, and first-session value perception are likely the most important areas to improve.

After 100h, negative sentiment remains comparatively low, staying around 11-16%. This suggests that long-term players are more stable once they understand the core survival loop and progression structure.

Icarus — What Drives Players Away



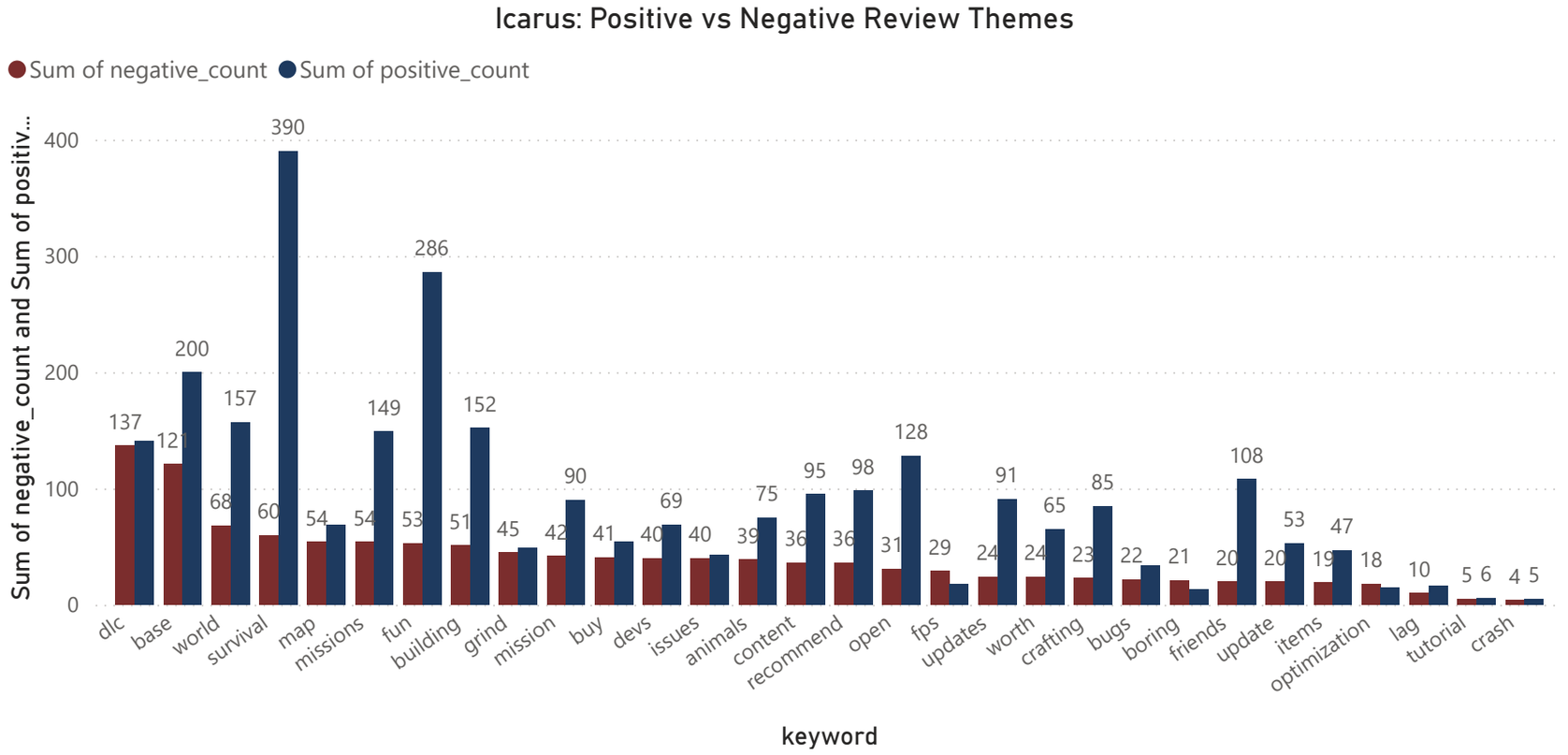
Key Finding

DLC is the leading negative theme in Icarus reviews (137 mentions), followed closely by base-game content concerns (121). This suggests the main issue is not rejection of the survival concept, but uncertainty around value: what feels complete in the base game versus what appears locked behind additional purchases.

Frequent mentions of world, map, missions, building, and grind point to a second layer of frustration around content depth and progression.

The product risk is that DLC may be perceived as replacing, rather than extending, the core experience.

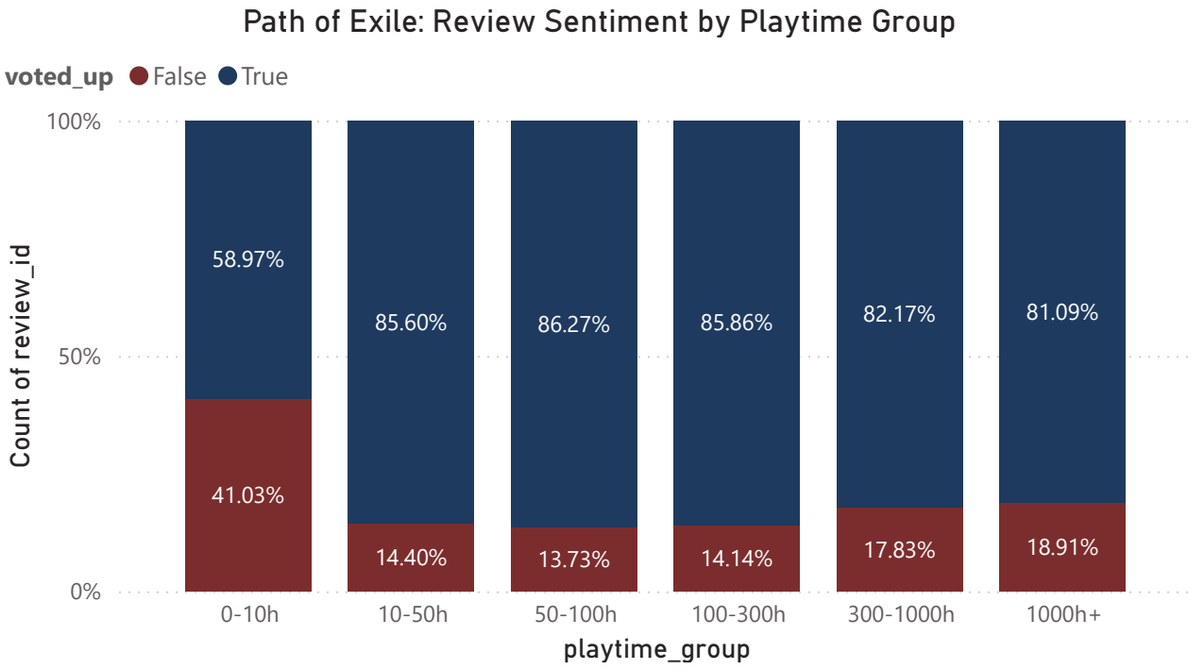
Icarus — Praise vs. Frustration



Key Findings

Icarus' core fantasy is well liked: survival, fun, world, building, and missions all skew strongly positive. Players who stay with the game tend to praise the survival loop and sandbox experience.
DLC is the main exception. With 137 negative mentions and 141 positive mentions, it is the most divisive theme, unlike survival and fun, which are overwhelmingly positive.
The issue is the base game and paid content offer the right value balance.

Path of Exile — The Learning Curve

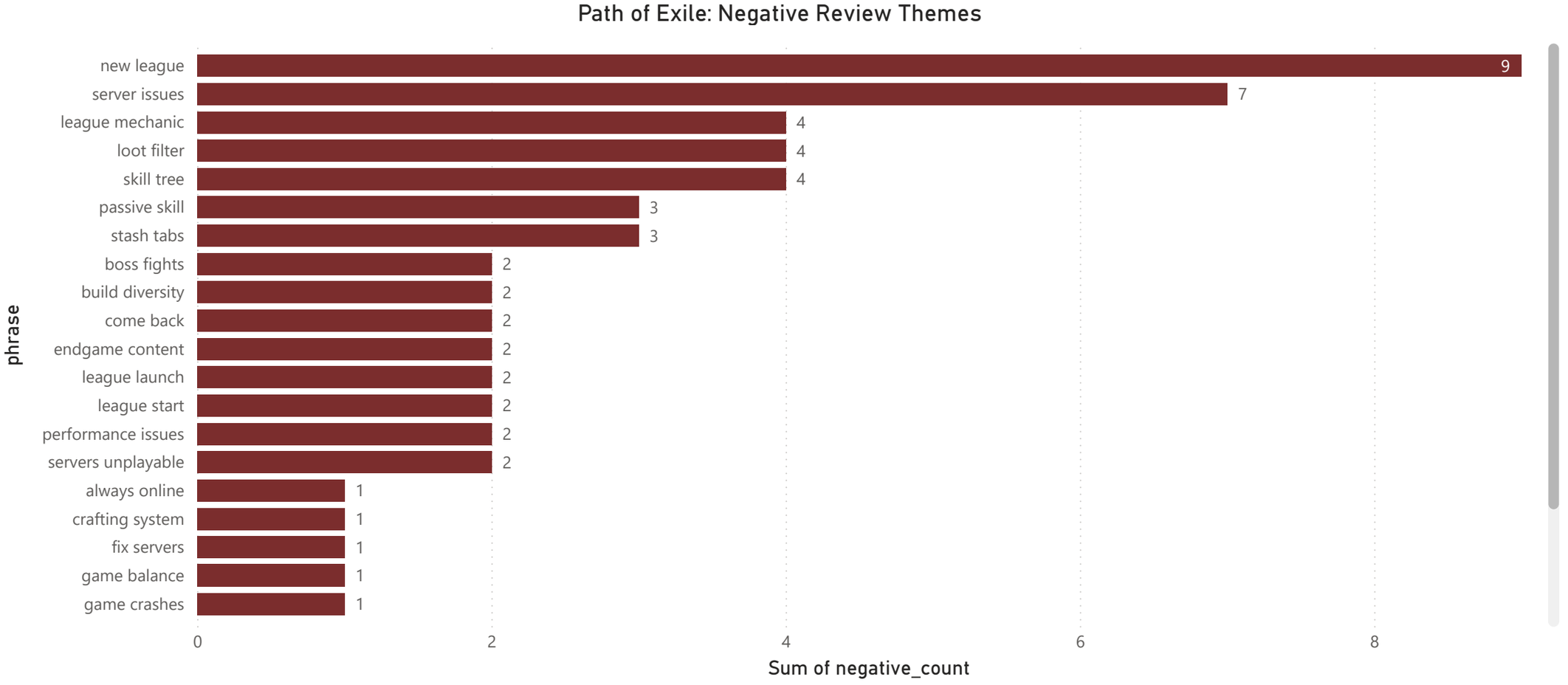


review_text	voted_up	playtime_hours
-	False	185.72
-	False	293.85
- buys house of mirrors - 1 > 2 > 4 > 0	True	1,583.77
-- playing 3.28 -- just placeholder review seems the game has improved a lot since my last review which was not recommended, giving a fair shot now that I'm kinda returning to it, but not sure if I'll play as much as I can due to limited time to play	True	271.03
!	True	563.45
"Ban for third party usage" Bro all I did was not playing the game, my ban was unappealable for no reason whatsoever. Maybe try using your brain for once, GGG. What a bummer.	False	110.62
"dV cuck: I don't see any method at all, sir. poe 1 chad: I expected someone like you. What did you expect? Are you an assassin? dV cuck: I'm a soldier. poe 1 chad: You're neither. You're an errand boy, sent by grocery clerks, to	True	1,248.00

Key Findings

Path of Exile's main sentiment risk is the first 10 hours: negative review rate starts at 41.0%, then falls to around 14% once players pass the initial learning curve.
This suggests that players do not reject PoE's depth itself; the harder problem is the entry path into that depth, including build uncertainty, UI friction, and reliance on external guides.
For GGG, the opportunity is not to simplify PoE, but to build a better bridge into its complexity.

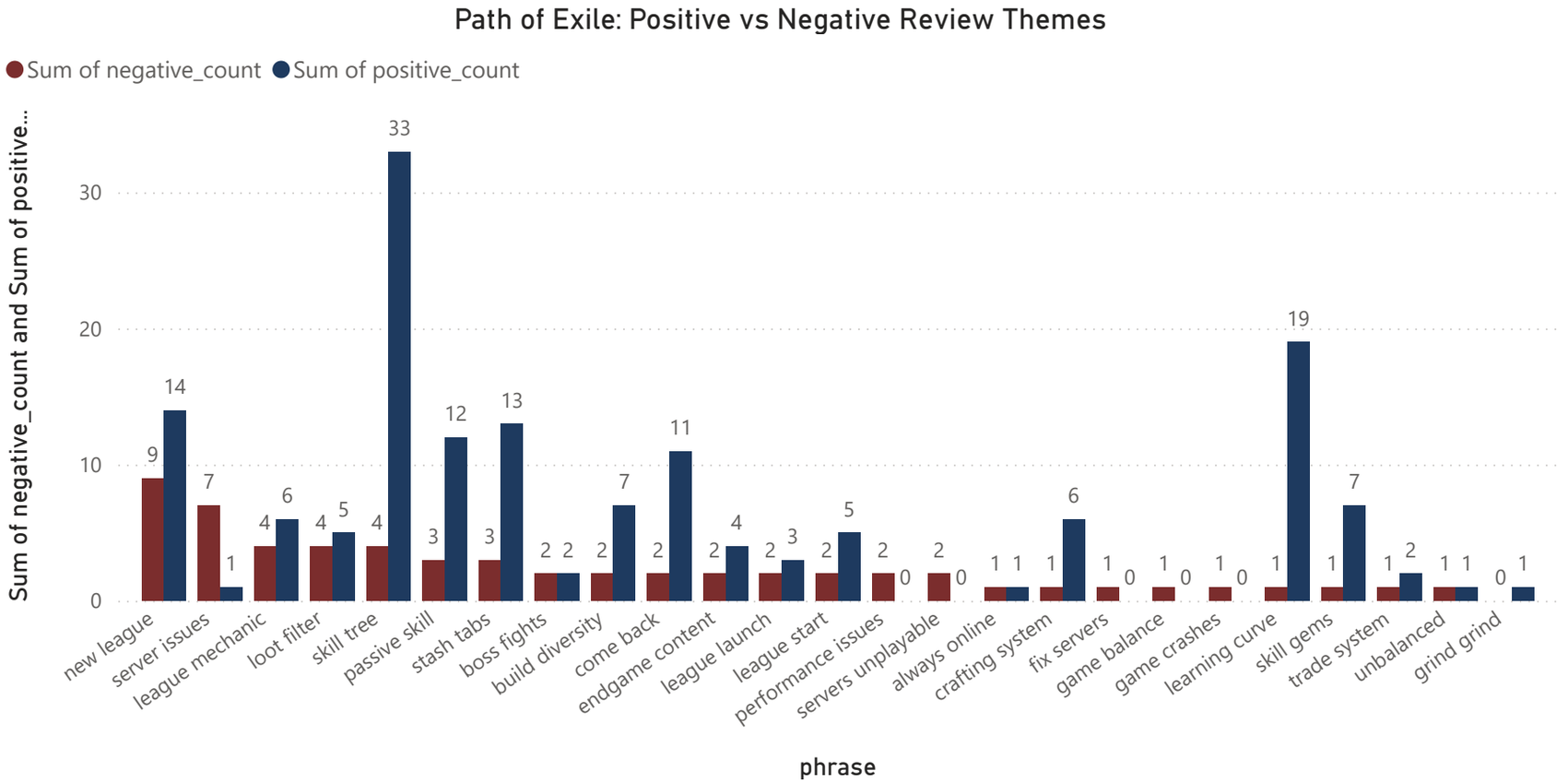
Path of Exile — Pain Points



Key Findings

PoE's negative themes point to seasonal delivery risk. "New league" and "server issues" lead the list, followed by league mechanics, loot filter, and skill tree. This suggests that dissatisfaction is concentrated around league launch windows, when players judge the stability, clarity, and value of the new update cycle. The main risk is the quality of each league's first-week experience.

Path of Exile — What Players Talk About



Key Findings

PoE's strongest positive signals are about depth: skill tree, learning curve, endgame content, and build diversity all skew positive.
This suggests that complexity becomes a feature for players who stay, even if it creates early onboarding friction.
Negative themes are more distributed, led by new league, server issues, and league mechanics. For GGG, the challenge is preserving depth while reducing the cost of entry.

Conclusions

Three Games, Three Different Review Signals

Apex Legends: The core gameplay signal remains strong in mid-playtime reviews, but trust-related complaints rise again after 300h. Negative sentiment falls to 21.9% at 50-100h, then rises to 42-43% after 300h, pointing to cheating, servers, ranked systems, and developer response. Priority areas: competitive integrity, matchmaking trust, and visible player communication.

Icarus: Early conversion is the main review-based risk. The 0-10h negative rate is highest at 59.7%, then falls below 20% after 50h. Priority areas: onboarding, pacing, technical stability, and base-game vs DLC value perception.

Path of Exile: The challenge is the entry path into depth. Negative rate starts at 41.0% in the first 10h, then stabilises around 14-19% after the learning curve. Priority areas: onboarding clarity, build guidance, UI friction, and first-week league stability.

Early-stage risk differs by game: Apex faces early trust and fairness concerns that later return at high playtime; Icarus needs to prove value earlier; Path of Exile needs to translate depth better.

The common thread: Players can forgive difficulty. They are less willing to forgive a game that feels unfair, unclear, unstable, or poorly supported.

Method limitation: Keyword extraction cannot capture every synonym, sarcastic comment, or context-dependent complaint, so theme counts should be treated as directional signals rather than exhaustive measurements.

Negative Review Rate by Playtime Stage

game	0-10h	10-50h	50-100h	100-300h	300-1000h	1000h+
Apex Legends	54.69%	26.96%	21.91%	29.07%	42.25%	43.16%
Icarus	59.66%	23.64%	19.49%	11.09%	15.29%	16.22%
Path of Exile	41.03%	14.40%	13.73%	14.14%	17.83%	18.91%